



**U.S. DEPARTMENT
OF STATE**

MYANMAR'S FOREVER WAR

AND THE UNITED STATES PLACE IN IT

DATE

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Executive Statement

Myanmar has been in continuous conflict since its independence, with over 25 ethnic armed groups fighting for autonomy against the military junta, the Tatmadaw. Efforts at peace, including the Nationwide Ceasefire Agreement and 2011 democratic reforms, collapsed, culminating in the 2021 coup and the Rohingya genocide. The international response has been limited despite the United Nations' Responsibility to Protect (R2P).

This policy brief recommends that the U.S. take a supporting diplomatic role in helping achieve peace in Myanmar. First, the U.S. should encourage foreign actors to act as peacekeepers, ensuring the Tatmadaw and ethnic militias honor peace agreements. Second, the U.S. should mediate negotiations, ensuring ethnic militias retain their arms as a safeguard and helping to construct a functioning democracy. Lastly, the U.S. should advocate for human rights protections and future accountability for war crimes, focusing on creating a framework for justice moving forward. These efforts can help create the conditions necessary for lasting peace in Myanmar.

These efforts could lead to lasting peace in Myanmar, with reduced violence, greater political inclusion, and a framework for future accountability through the means of a functional democracy and political arena.

Introduction

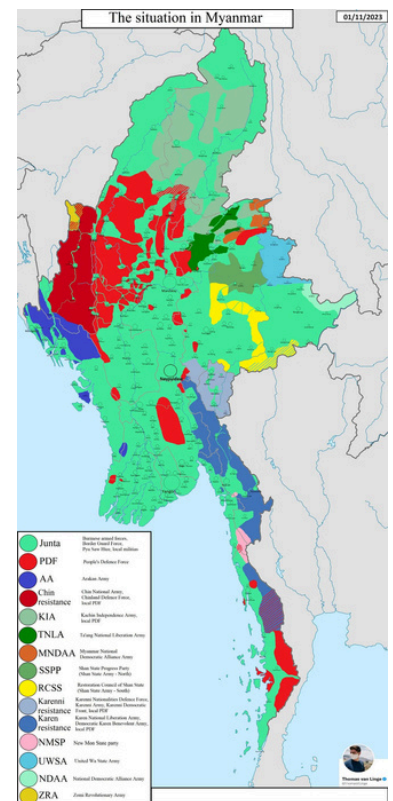
The prospects of peace within the Southeast Asian nation of Myanmar have always been lucrative, yet unstable. This can best be seen in the last major attempt to end the conflict with the Nationwide Ceasefire Agreement in 2015, which spurred a six-year transition towards peace.¹

This initial peace settlement had potential as it initially had eight of the fifteen major militias signed on to a ceasefire with two more signing on the next year.²

However, this peace was short-lived when the Tatmadaw and its political allies overthrew the democratically elected government in 2021 citing claims that the previous election had been rigged in the favor of the National League for Democracy (NLD). This has led to the current situation in Myanmar where both the democratic forces and ethnic groups have taken up arms as seen in Figure 1.

Figure 1. Current Map of Myanmar . Reddit (2023)³

The current U.S. activity in Myanmar is primarily directed toward the USAID's mission there and the economic sanctions levied on the Tatmadaw regime. The former is there to promote democratic institutions and provide funding for humanitarian assistance of the Rohingya people and to condemn any actions that perpetuate human rights violations.⁴



These actions are helpful in the short term and do provide immediate relief to the areas that are most affected by the conflict. However, these actions do little to stem the continuation of ethnic violence which is currently being conducted by the Tatmadaw. Reports from U.N. human rights investigators found the Tatmadaw attacking "villages that have fallen to opposition groups, carrying out beheadings, gang rapes, and torture, with women, children and the elderly among the victims".⁵

1. Wai Moe and Thomas Fuller, "Myanmar and 8 Ethnic Groups Sign Cease-Fire, but Doubts Remain," The New York Times, October 15, 2015, <https://www.nytimes.com/2015/10/16/world/asia/myanmar-ceasefire-armed-ethnic-groups.html>.
 2. "2 Groups Join Myanmar Government's Peace Process," AP News, February 13, 2018, <https://apnews.com/general-news-e668736f3c4b44cfa310addefd4da1e3>.
 3. Thomas Van Linge, "Latest Map of the Civil War," Reddit, January 11, 2023, https://www.reddit.com/r/Myanmarcombatfootage/comments/17mm10r/latest_map_of_the_civil_war/.
 4. "Press Releases: Basic Page: Burma," U.S. Agency for International Development, September 24, 2024, <https://www.usaid.gov/burma/press-releases>.
 5. Edith M. Lederer, "Un Expert: Myanmar's Desperate Military Ramps up Attacks Including Beheadings, Rapes and Torture," AP News, November 22, 2024, <https://apnews.com/article/un-myanmar-military-attacks-rights-violations-rohingya-f38f5e3f0a50d4ce64891fc6739fa8e5>.

As the war continues, and the need for international intervention becomes more apparent to counteract the human rights violations happening, the United States must be in a position to help in a supporting role.

In this policy brief, we outline three recommendations for the USDOS to support peace efforts in Myanmar. These include directing USDOS personnel to engage with international actors on the issue of Myanmar, assisting them in the peace process, and ensuring both the Tatmadaw and ethnic militias uphold their commitments to peace agreements.

Methodology

When addressing the Myanmar Civil War, it is important to carefully look at why previous peace efforts have failed and what obstacles continue to prevent peace from taking hold. Understanding these challenges is key to finding a solution. In addition, it's crucial to consider the role of international actors like China, the United States, and the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN). See the nations that makeup ASEAN in figure 2. Each of these players influences the conflict in different ways, whether through direct involvement, economic support, or diplomatic pressure. Knowing how these countries and groups interact with Myanmar will help in creating a path toward lasting peace.

Figure 2. ASEAN Nations. Mulyana (2022)⁶



We will explore the main ways ceasefires and peace agreements have taken place in Myanmar, focusing on the events from 2008, when the country began its democratization efforts, to the present. This will help U.S. officials understand which peace attempts were most successful and the reasons behind their failures. Additionally, we will highlight any recurring patterns or trends in peace-making that have appeared both within and outside of this time frame.

This information will be drawn from academic research by leading experts on civil wars and the case of Myanmar, such as Jiwon Lee, Barbara F. Walter, Armand Sadvoschi, and others, who offer valuable insights into the failures and recurring patterns of peace attempts in Myanmar.

The literature on the actions of international actors will be gathered through official statements and actions from key organizations and nations involved in Myanmar's conflict. This includes statements from ASEAN, USAID, the USDOS, the United Nations (UN), the People's Republic of China (PRC), and credible officials representing these entities. These sources will provide insight into the roles these actors have played and their potential influence on the peace process in Myanmar.

Results

Starting with the most active international actor within Myanmar, **China**, their history with the conflict can be dated back to their support of the Wa who live on the border between Myanmar and China. However, they have been an unreliable partner to both sides. Their support of both the Wa and the Tatmadaw has been inconsistent as events change such as the partial democratization which occurred in the 2010s.

6.Yana Mulyana, "ASEAN Association of Southeast Asian Nations Map Illustration Stock Vector - Illustration of Land, ASEAN: 251506262," Dreamstime, July 14, 2022, <https://www.dreamstime.com/asean-association-southeast-asian-nations-map-illustration-asean-association-southeast-asian-nations-map-vector-illustration-image251506262>.

7.Magnus Fiskesjö, "The Wa of Myanmar and China's Quest for Global Dominance," The Journal of Asian Studies 82, no. 4 (August 16, 2023): 759–61, <https://doi.org/10.1215/00219118-10773671>. Pp 1.

As well as the closure of various economic developments such as the Myitsone Dam project.⁸

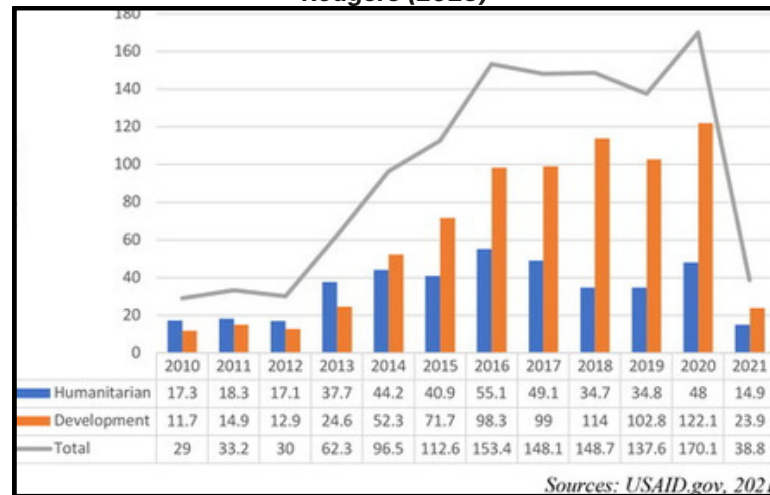
Beijing has rekindled relations with Myanmar in recent years after the 2021 Coup, with recent talks between Myanmar Leader Min Aung Hlaing Meets with Wang Yi on the prospects of new economic developments and the improvement of the trade corridor in Myanmar.⁹ As well as Chinese assistance internationally within the United Nations Security Council where Beijing defended and vetoed resolutions critical to Myanmar.^{10 11} However, this policy change only proves the fact that China is an international factor that changes with the wind and doesn't provide the stability needed to support a solution to the civil war's commitment problem.

The **ASEAN's** primary relationship is contingent upon the progress made by the Myanmar government in areas such as peacebuilding and human rights protection, with rewards in the form of international prestige and recognition for any positive advancements. This can best be shown by the organization's current initiative towards peace called the "Five Point Plan" and the repercussions it has placed on Myanmar till then.

The plan consists of five key points: an immediate cessation of violence, especially against civilians; the initiation of an inclusive national dialogue involving all stakeholders to achieve a peaceful and democratic resolution; the provision of humanitarian assistance to those in need, including internally displaced persons, without discrimination; the active engagement of ASEAN through a Special Envoy to facilitate dialogue and build trust among all parties; and continuous monitoring of progress, with regular consultations and transparent reporting.¹² Until then, Myanmar will forfeit any opportunity to lead

ASEAN, with the nation already losing its leadership role to the Philippines in 2026.¹³ This represents a significant external force in terms of prestige. However, beyond symbolism and international recognition, it does little to exert actual physical pressure or directly address the underlying issues prolonging the conflict.

Figure 3. USAID to Myanmar from 2010-2021.¹⁴
Rodgers (2023)



Finally, the **United States'** influence in Myanmar has been limited to three actions: aid, sanctions, and immigration. Starting with aid, Washington has been using USAID to support humanitarian missions and causes within the nation. As of recently, this has been in response to the genocide of the Rohingya with the U.S. sending \$129 million through USAID and nearly \$70 million from the U.S. Department of State.¹⁵ However, as a whole aid from Washington has been on a downturn ever since the 2021 Coup, see Figure 3. This is primarily due to both the coup going against Washington's interest in increased democracy in Myanmar and the fact that increased human rights violations make Myanmar an unlikely candidate for USAID.

This trend is inverse with the subject of sanctions. This can be seen with the Department of State releasing 41 press releases on new sanctions on the Myanmar Military Government compared to 8 before the coup.¹⁶

8. Xinhua, "China, Myanmar Agree on Dam Issue," archive.shine.cn, August 18, 2016, <https://archive.shine.cn/nation/China-Myanmar-agree-on-dam-issue/shdaily.shtml>.

9. Aung Hlaing, Myanmar leader Min Aung Hlaing meets with Wang Yi, August 14, 2024, <http://zurich.china-consulate.gov.cn/det/szyw/202408/11474224.htm>.

10. U.N. Security Council, "Security Council Demands Immediate End to Violence in Myanmar, Urges Restraint, Release of Arbitrarily Detained Prisoners, Adopting Resolution 2669 (2022) | Meetings Coverage and Press Releases," United Nations, December 21, 2022, <https://press.un.org/en/2022/sc15159.doc.htm>.

11. BBC, "Myanmar Coup: China Blocks UN Condemnation as Protest Grows," BBC News, February 3, 2021, <https://www.bbc.com/news/world-asia-55913947>.

12. ASEAN, "ASEAN Leaders' Review and Decision on The ...," ASEAN LAO PDR 2024, October 9, 2024, https://asean.org/wp-content/uploads/2024/10/4-Final_Review-and-Decision-of-the-ASEAN-LEADERS-on-the-5PC-2024.pdf.

13. ASEAN, "ASEAN Leaders' Review and Decision on The ...," ASEAN LAO PDR 2024, October 9, 2024, https://asean.org/wp-content/uploads/2024/10/4-Final_Review-and-Decision-of-the-ASEAN-LEADERS-on-the-5PC-2024.pdf.

14. Roy Anthony Rogers, Wui Chern Liew, and Jatswan Singh Sidhu, "The United States' Myanmar Policy after the 2021 Military Coup and Its Prospects under China-US Strategic Competition," Asian Affairs: An American Review 50, no. 4 (October 2, 2023): 244-75, <https://doi.org/10.1080/00927678.2023.2262354>.

15. USAID Press Office, "The United States Announces Nearly \$199 Million in Additional Humanitarian Assistance for the Rohingya Refugee Crisis: Press Release," U.S. Agency for International Development, September 24, 2024, <https://www.usaid.gov/news-information/press-releases/sep-24-2024-united-states-announces-nearly-199-million-additional-humanitarian-assistance-rohingya-refugee-crisis>.

16. US Department of State, "Burma Press Releases On Sanctions," U.S. Department of State, January 31, 2024, <https://www.state.gov/burma-sanctions/>.

These sanctions both directly target specific members of the Tatmadaw as well as industries such as Myanma Oil and Myanmar Jade.

Additionally, General Crutchfield and Anne Richard, state that the sanctions rose during the Biden administration in direct response to the 2021 Coup and the reverse of democratic values and the human rights violations that were occurring in the nation.¹⁷

The final primary means of contact between Washington and Naypyidaw is through immigration. The United States has had an inconsistent record on Burmese entry into the states. This inconsistency primarily comes from administration change. In 2015 around 4,000 Burmese migrated to the United States. In 2016 that dropped to 3,000 and in 2019 that dropped to 600 total people. Keep in mind that throughout the entire decade around 125,000 people migrated from Myanmar to the United States majority of which happened under the Obama Administration.¹⁸

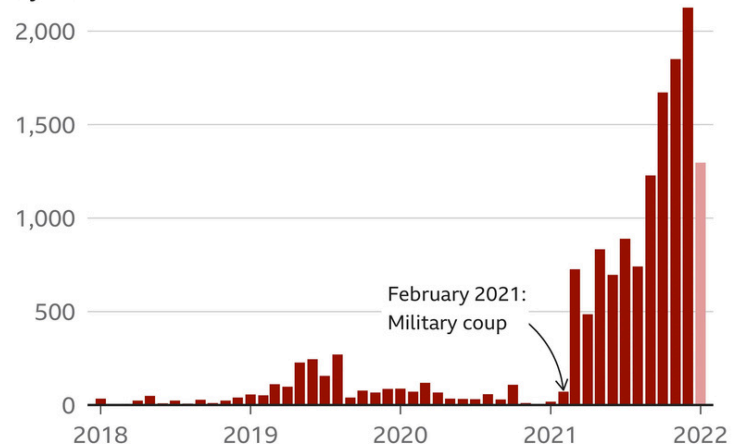
The Biden administration has since reversed course, allowing more migrants than the Trump administration did. However, the inconsistency in Washington's policy on something as fundamental as migration creates a larger problem of commitment, which is evident on the international stage.

Conclusions

The Myanmar civil war has persisted since the country's post-colonial era, with peace remaining elusive due to both sides' failure to resolve their commitment problems. The 2021 coup further exacerbated the situation, destroying the trust that had been building between ethnic militias and the military government during Myanmar's democratic transition in the 2010s.

Figure 4. 2018-2022 Number of Reported Deaths in Myanmar. Win (2022)

The conflict in Myanmar has grown deadlier
Number of reported deaths from conflict and demonstrations, by month



Note: Data up to 21 January 2022

Source: Armed Conflict Location & Event Data Project (ACLED)

BBC

The erosion of trust has undermined prospects for peace in Myanmar. The Tatmadaw, Myanmar's military, is no longer trusted to refrain from attacking ethnic groups like the Rohingya or using politics to resolve issues. As a result, the conflict has escalated, with ethnic militias viewing the battlefield as their only means of addressing grievances. This can be seen by the fact that ceasefires often leave rebels with weapons, which is unusual in civil wars.¹⁹ It also leads to more casualties as seen in figure 4.

A potential solution is to replace trust in the Tatmadaw with trust in international actors. However, the main international players (China, the United States, and ASEAN) are inconsistent in their engagement, making them unreliable sources of trust for peace negotiations.

Recommendation

This underlines the need for American diplomats working in Myanmar to understand the root causes of prolonging the conflict and to address these issues through collaborative efforts with the international community and key actors committed to ending the war.

To address the deep distrust that fuels the conflict, American diplomats should take several critical steps. First, they should encourage China to play a role as a peacekeeper, ensuring that both the Tatmadaw and ethnic militias honor peace agreements. Additionally, the U.S. should mediate negotiations, advocating for ethnic militias to retain their arms as a safeguard while assisting in the creation of a functional democracy. Finally, the U.S. must push for stronger human rights protections and future accountability for war crimes, focusing on building a lasting framework for justice. These efforts can help establish the conditions necessary for sustainable peace in Myanmar.

Recruiting Foreign Efforts For Peace-Keeping

One of the key factors for peace in Myanmar is the presence of an actor who can promote stability and shift the focus from military action to political solutions. While the United States or the United Nations would ideally play this role, it's not feasible due to Beijing's proximity, influence, and UN Security Council veto. Therefore, increased coordination between Beijing and Washington on Myanmar could yield positive outcomes.

ASEAN's regional prestige could also be leveraged for negotiations, with the promise of reinstating Myanmar as leader of the organization, combined with economic incentives and sanctions removal from both China and the U.S. These efforts would enable key international actors to align their actions, providing security guarantees for ethnic militias and deterring the Tatmadaw from hostile actions like those in 2021. This could come in the form of collective peace plans such as an amended *Five Point Plan*.

Endorsement of the Retention of Rebel Arms

Additionally, allowing ethnic groups to retain their weapons helps address the concerns and commitment issues of the rebels as they transition toward a political solution. This practice provides a sense of security and ensures that the ethnic militias feel they are not being disarmed without guarantees of protection or political progress. Therefore, U.S. diplomats should actively support the continuation of these policies in future peace talks, recognizing their importance in building trust and facilitating a durable resolution to the conflict.

Endorsement of the Retention of Rebel Arms

Lastly, the U.S. Department of State should prioritize advocating for stronger human rights protections and accountability for war crimes in Myanmar, focusing on establishing a lasting framework for justice. This can be achieved by supporting international efforts to investigate and prosecute perpetrators, strengthening human rights organizations, and promoting an independent judicial process. Holding violators accountable will help reduce impunity, build trust among communities, and pave the way for long-term peace. These efforts will also contribute to creating a fair and inclusive system essential for Myanmar's sustainable peace and stability.

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The Forever War of Myanmar

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Introduction

Myanmar, also known as Burma, is the only country that has been in conflict every year since independence.¹ Yet, out of the seventy-six years in which Myanmar has enjoyed both its independence and has been in conflict, not a single one of those years included the event of an inter-state conflict. Rather, Myanmar has had a chronic case of internal conflicts and civil wars. The primary reason for the continuation of this conflict lies in the objectives of the various ethnic groups that make up Myanmar and account for around one-third of the population.² There are over 25 armed factions that operate within Myanmar with the most notable being the Kachin and the Wa.³ The objectives of the various ethnic groups were a plight for self-determination and autonomy from an increasingly prosecuting military government, called the Tatmadaw came to power after the 1964 coup.⁴ These persecutions can be seen through examples of ethnic genocide such as the Rohingya genocide where in 2016-17 the Tatmadaw went on a brutal campaign against the Rohingya, killing thousands of people and displacing many more.⁵ While there have been attempts at peace with both the Tatmadaw granting autonomy to some groups and attempting to build a democratic state, they have not lasted. The most recent example of this comes from the 2011 democratic reforms which the Tatmadaw implemented in hopes for it to lead to ceasefires between the government and the various ethnic groups.⁶ These ceasefires did eventually come with the Nationwide Ceasefire Agreement which eight out of the fifteen major armed ethnic groups signed with multiple more joining in later years.⁷ The agreement collapsed

¹Alvaro Aguirre, "The Risk of Civil Conflicts as a Determinant of Political Institutions," *European Journal of Political Economy* 42 (March 2016): 36–59, <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ejpolco.2016.01.002>. Pp 49.

²Lindsay Maizland, "Myanmar's Troubled History: Coups, Military Rule, and Ethnic Conflict," Council on Foreign Relations, January 31, 2022, <https://www.cfr.org/backgrounder/myanmar-history-coup-military-rule-ethnic-conflict-rohingya>.

³Antonio Graceffo, "Backgrounder: Ethnic Armies in Myanmar Civil War," Geopolitical Monitor, August 12, 2024, <https://www.geopoliticalmonitor.com/backgrounder-ethnic-armies-in-the-myanmar-civil-war/>.

⁴Max Hoque Kazi et al., "The Civil War in Myanmar," February 6, 2023, <https://carleton.ca/cifp/wp-content/uploads/Myanmar-Conflict-Diagnostic-2023.pdf>.

⁵Lindsay Maizland, "Myanmar's Troubled History: Coups, Military Rule, and Ethnic Conflict," Council on Foreign Relations, January 31, 2022, <https://www.cfr.org/backgrounder/myanmar-history-coup-military-rule-ethnic-conflict-rohingya>.

⁶Jiwon Lee, "Settlements in the Civil Wars of Myanmar and Sri Lanka: The Success, Failure and Deception of the Peace Process," *Sage Journals*, April 5, 2016, <https://doi.org/10.1177/0976399615624057>.

⁷Wai Moe and Thomas Fuller, "Myanmar and 8 Ethnic Groups Sign Cease-Fire, but Doubts Remain," *The New York Times*, October 15, 2015, <https://www.nytimes.com/2015/10/16/world/asia/myanmar-ceasefire-armed-ethnic-groups.html>.

after the 2021 coup, when the Tatmadaw, citing election fraud, established the State Administration Council (SAC) following a surprising loss to the National League for Democracy (NLD). This led to the ongoing civil conflict, with the Tatmadaw fighting armed ethnic groups and the NLD's remnant, the People's Defence Force (PDF). Myanmar's persistent civil unrest is a unique anomaly, as the country has never experienced lasting peace. The situation is fueled by the Tatmadaw's escalating conflict with rebels, a lack of trust, and inconsistent foreign support, particularly from China. True peace can only be achieved through the Tatmadaw's shift toward democracy, reconciliation, and stronger international intervention, especially from China.

A. An Escalating Commitment Problem

Peace isn't an improbability within Myanmar but rather isn't consistent around the entire country. This can be seen with the previous democratic transition and the ceasefires that followed. The former event was supposed to be a backdrop to bring up the Tatmadaw's reputation as simply the military force within Myanmar, while not losing its administrative influence by allowing itself to keep a minimum of twenty-five percent of the legislature.⁸ In exchange, they gave NLD "free elections, freedom of the press, and the formation of a civilian government".⁹ This exchange within itself is a solution to the commitment problem that the military has, or even framed as a solution towards a Thucydides trap situation. Within this deal, the Tatmadaw would traditionally be a steady or declining power while the democratic forces in Myanmar, NLD, would be the rising power as more people protest and strive for democracy. Thus, the Tatmadaw created a deal that caps its potential loss in a democratic transition to a point where it can still veto legislation that doesn't support its cause.

⁸Maung Aung Myoe, "9, Partnership in Politics: The Tatmadaw and the NLD in Myanmar since 2016," *Myanmar Transformed?*, December 31, 2018, 201–30, <https://doi.org/10.1355/9789814818551-013>.

⁹Heiduk, "Civil War in Myanmar," Stiftung Wissenschaft und Politik (SWP), accessed November 14, 2024, <https://www.swp-berlin.org/10.18449/2021C35>. Pp 2.

This approach of capping potential losses that could come from a failure of a commitment problem continues into the realm of ceasefires. This is done by allowing “the ethnic leaders were allowed to keep arms, territories, and administrations, and a ceasefire under these terms was considered a better alternative”.¹⁰ Thus, if the Tatmadaw backtracks on its agreement or starts attacking other ethnic groups, the ethnic groups that did sign would be able to see the writing on the wall and be able to act accordingly. To be frank, this is the bargaining model at work as both sides don’t want to be held to a commitment problem but also don’t want to continue the loss that would occur through conflict. After the gradual transition towards democracy, the Tatmadaw convened the Nationwide Ceasefire Agreement under this strategy which led to eight out of the fifteen combating ethnic groups signing into a ceasefire. While none of the major armed ethnic groups, such as the Kachin and the Wa, there was hope that eventually, that would change as two more groups eventually did sign in the coming years.^{11 12} Thus, given time there was a possibility that the remainder of the group.

However, as time came the only thing to arrive was the fact that the Tatmadaw had broken the commitment. This started in 2016 with the Rohingya genocide, which was aided by the fact that Aung San Suu Kyi, the State Counsellor of Myanmar at that time, stated “The Rohingya are foreigners who have no place in Myanmar”.¹³ This just stoked the fears of the other ethnic minorities as it had seemed that the Byrma majority government would not only not defend their fellow citizens, even though Myanmar formally protects all of its 135 minorities, but would also encourage their destruction and displacement.¹⁴ This simply made it so that

¹⁰ Jiwon Lee, “Settlements in the Civil Wars of Myanmar and Sri Lanka: The Success, Failure and Deception of the Peace Process,” *Sage Journals*, April 5, 2016, <https://doi.org/10.1177/0976399615624057>.

¹¹ Wai Moe and Thomas Fuller, “Myanmar and 8 Ethnic Groups Sign Cease-Fire, but Doubts Remain,” *The New York Times*, October 15, 2015, <https://www.nytimes.com/2015/10/16/world/asia/myanmar-ceasefire-armed-ethnic-groups.html>.

¹² “2 Groups Join Myanmar Government’s Peace Process,” *AP News*, February 13, 2018, <https://apnews.com/general-news-e668736f3c4b44cfa310addefd4da1e3>.

¹³ Armand Sadovschi, “Post-Colonial Identity and Power Politics. the Case of Myanmar’s Civil War,” *EIRP Proceedings*, July 31, 2024, <https://dp.univ-danubius.ro/index.php/EIRP/article/view/490>. Pp 7.

¹⁴ Armand Sadovschi, “Post-Colonial Identity and Power Politics. the Case of Myanmar’s Civil War,” *EIRP Proceedings*, July 31, 2024, <https://dp.univ-danubius.ro/index.php/EIRP/article/view/490>. Pp 3.

Rohingya's case was seen as the canary in the mine causing "ethnic minorities to now temporarily unite only by their common resentments towards the majoritarian Bamarese and the military junta".¹⁵ It cannot be understated how much this sets back the possibility of peace as any of the potential reputation that the Tatmadaw and the unified government would have had in being a just authority would have been squandered. Thus, creating even greater distrust and holding back all ethnic groups from committing to a national ceasefire. To the point that the Myanmar government would eventually start labeling groups such as the Myanmar National Democratic Alliance Army (MNDAA), Ta'ang National Liberation Army (TNLA), and Arakan Army as terrorist organizations.¹⁶

As for the Government, that union would also fall apart from the 2021 coup. This led to not only ethnic groups being distrustful of the government but also the democratic forces in that government actively rebelling and becoming distrustful of any future attempts at democratization from the Tatmadaw. Overall, the rightful distrust that is felt by the various ethnic groups about the Tatmadaw makes the chance that both sides commit to a long-term peace slim to none.

B. International Influences, Or Lack Thereof

There is a variety of international actors which interact with Myanmar and the land it inhabits. This includes the United States, India, terrorist organizations, and China. However, within the confines of this civil war, these actors interaction is limited and their influence is even more so. Starting with the United States, its main intervention in the conflict is through economic means by levying sanctions on the Tatmadaw-led government due to their atrocities.¹⁷ This is the approach that the majority of the Western world took when addressing the onset of the most

¹⁵Armand Sadovschi, "Post-Colonial Identity and Power Politics. the Case of Myanmar's Civil War," EIRP Proceedings, July 31, 2024, <https://dp.univ-danubius.ro/index.php/EIRP/article/view/490>. Pp 7.

¹⁶Al Jazeera, "Myanmar Regime Labels Key Ethnic Armed Groups 'terrorist' Organisations," Al Jazeera, September 5, 2024, <https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2024/9/4/myanmar-regime-labels-key-ethnic-armed-groups-terrorist-organisations>.

¹⁷Celia Hatton, "Myanmar: Firms across 13 Countries Supporting Military with Training & Weaponry Materials, UN Officials Find," Business & Human Rights Resource Centre, January 16, 2023, <https://www.business-humanrights.org/en/latest-news/myanmar-firms-across-13-countries-supporting-military-with-training-and-weaponry-materials-un-officials-find/>.

recent events of the conflict, especially the genocide and reversal of democratic practices. This practice, while effective at damping and power of the Tatmadaw, does little in terms of the conflict on the ground. As for India, their relationship is just as non-contact as the United States with the primary mode of discussion which is made by Myanmar detaining and extraditing terrorists and militants that have been attacking India but harboring in Myanmar.¹⁸ From an initial point of view, this would seem like Myanmar would be a state where passive support is allowed to international terrorist groups due to the weakness prevented from the state due to the prolonged civil war. However, this is not the case. In a statement from Ambassador Hau Do Suan, Permanent Representative of Myanmar to the United Nations, he states “Recently, some FTFs had tried to enter Myanmar territory from one of our neighboring countries in Southeast Asia in an attempt to reinforce ARSA terrorist activities”.¹⁹ While this would symbolize the presence of an international terrorist organization and the potential for future passive support depending on the changes in the power of the Tatmadaw. It also means that for the last couple of decades, the military government has been successful, for the most part, in localizing this conflict strictly inside Myanmar. The only other exception to that is with its relationship with China.

Chinese involvement in the conflict has been the longest-standing, through different methods and on different sides of the civil conflict. China has supported the Tatmadaw through both resources such as copper but also through international protection by vetoing any harmful resolutions within the United Nations Security Council.^{20 21} They also supply physical investment

¹⁸Ne Now News, “Myanmar Army Hands over 22 ‘most Wanted Militants’ from Northeast India, Including Top UNLF and NDFB Commanders,” NorthEast Now, November 11, 2021, <https://nenow.in/top-news/myanmar-army-hands-over-22-most-wanted-militants-from-northeast-india-including-top-unlf-and-ndfb-commanders.html>.

¹⁹Hau Suan, “Myanmar Statement -- International Terrorism,” Statement by Ambassador Hau Do Suan, Permanent Representative of Myanmar to the United Nations on Agenda Item 109 “Measure to Eliminate International Terrorism” at the Sixth Committee of the 74th Session of the United Nations General Assembly, accessed November 15, 2024, https://www.un.org/en/ga/sixth/74/pdfs/statements/int_terrorism/myanmar.pdf.

²⁰Celia Hatton, “Myanmar: Firms across 13 Countries Supporting Military with Training & Weaponry Materials, UN Officials Find,” Business & Human Rights Resource Centre, January 16, 2023, <https://www.business-humanrights.org/en/latest-news/myanmar-firms-across-13-countries-supporting-military-with-training-and-weaponry-materials-un-officials-find/>.

²¹United Nations, “Security Council Fails to Adopt Draft Resolution on Myanmar, Owing to Negative Votes by China, Russian Federation | Meetings Coverage and Press Releases,” United Nations, 2007, <https://press.un.org/en/2007/sc8939.doc.htm>.

by building the “Kyaukphyu deep-sea port and the proposed Myitsone Dam project”.²² However, Chinese actions within Burma aren’t always to the benefit of the national government. This can be seen with its economic ties and support of the Wa State and the communist faction that previously occupied it. China would buy rare earth materials from them and even safe-harbored Communist leaders when they were exiled from Myanmar in a form of passive support.²³ Another example of waning Chinese aid is after the democratic reforms where investments from China decreased or were even cut entirely. The most notable example of this came with the Myitsone Dam which was stopped after continual disagreement between the new democratic regime and China.²⁴ Altogether, the Myanmar civil war has a slew of international actors that have the potential to change the conflict but the reality is that other than China none of them have the will nor intention to do so. Thus, the war will continue to be localized within the border of Myanmar.

C. Catch-22: The Proposal Of Peace

Given the fact that the conflict has lasted over seventy-six years with no resolution, it is good to say that peace is a less than probable outcome within the near future. Yet, it is not impossible. To get to this peace the following conditions must be met: Further Chinese involvement as a third party, further commitments to democratization, and the continuation of Myanmar policy in terms of letting ethnic groups keep their militias.

The most critical of these three factors is the involvement of China. While in the public view, interventions in civil wars just make them more messy, there are conditions for which interventions can promote peace. Barbara F. Walter, a political scientist with a focus on civil

²²Joaquin Matamis, “China in Myanmar: How the Game-Changing Neighbor Would Continue to Maintain Its Influence • Stimson Center,” Stimson Center, September 11, 2024, <https://www.stimson.org/2024/china-in-myanmar-how-the-game-changing-neighbor-would-continue-to-maintain-its-influence/>.

²³Magnus Fiskesjö, “The Wa of Myanmar and China’s Quest for Global Dominance,” *The Journal of Asian Studies* 82, no. 4 (August 16, 2023): 759–61, <https://doi.org/10.1215/00219118-10773671>. Pp 1.

²⁴Yun Sun, “China and the Changing Myanmar,” *Journal of Current Southeast Asian Affairs* 31, no. 4 (December 2012): 51–77, <https://doi.org/10.1177/186810341203100403>.

wars, states “Civil wars almost always chose to fight to the finish unless an outside power stepped in to guarantee a peace agreement...If a third party did not intervene, these talks usually failed”.²⁵ Walter further goes on to note that between 1940 to 1990 belligerents within civil wars were almost always unable to reach a negotiated peace without the guarantee of an outside force.²⁶ This is primarily because both sides aren’t able to sustain the commitment to peace without the threat of potentially being betrayed, such as the many times the Tatmadaw has betrayed the various ethnic groups and democratic forces in Myanmar. Thus, China, the only outside power interested in the conflict, must act as the enforcer of peace to counter-act the commitment problem at hand.

Secondly, the Tatmadaw must make a genuine commitment to building a functional democracy, allowing rebel groups to express their grievances through political, rather than military, means. This is one of the toughest challenges in the conflict, as it would require the Tatmadaw to relinquish or significantly weaken its control, as seen when its political party was limited to just 25% of the legislature. Furthermore, this would likely strain relations with China, given that the previous democratic government sought to distance itself from China in favor of closer ties with the United States. Thus, granting Myanmar’s minorities access to political power represents the most difficult obstacle to achieving peace.

The final proposal is the continuation of the Tatmadaw policy to allow rebel groups to keep their arms as a means to counteract the commitment problem. This is a requirement that is extremely abnormal within most civil war settlements but has been prevalent in cease-fires within Myanmar.²⁷ This allows the rebel groups to have a backdoor if the Tatmadaw deflects

²⁵Barbara F. Walter, “The Critical Barrier to Civil War Settlement,” *International Organization* 51, no. 3 (1997): 335–64, <https://doi.org/10.1162/002081897550384>. Pp. 335.

²⁶Barbara F. Walter, “The Critical Barrier to Civil War Settlement,” *International Organization* 51, no. 3 (1997): 335–64, <https://doi.org/10.1162/002081897550384>. Pp. 360.

²⁷Barbara F. Walter, “Bargaining Failures and Civil War,” *Annual Review of Political Science* 12, no. 1 (June 1, 2009): 243–61, <https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev.polisci.10.101405.135301>. Pp 246.

from its promises of peace or starts to initiate ethnic violence such as in the case seen with the Rohingya genocide. Additionally, it forced the Tatmadaw to calculate its options before committing to an offensive which would most likely be solved through the bargaining model within politics. As Clausewitz famously stated, “War is nothing but a continuation of politics by other means.”²⁸ By both allowing greater access to politics for the rebels and by leveraging the bargaining model to force the Tatmadaw to seek a political solution there is a way to seek peace within the forever war of Myanmar.

Conclusion

The conflict in Myanmar has lasted far beyond a single lifetime, with multiple attempts at peace ending in failure, the most significant being the 2021 coup d'état. The long duration of the conflict, combined with numerous betrayals during peace negotiations, has made the commitment problem between the two sides more entrenched than ever. The conflict is largely self-sustaining, with few outside actors directly or continuously involved, the main exception being China. As such, lasting peace in Myanmar seems highly improbable. With active attempts at peace, being dismissed by the side of the rebels.²⁹ However, "improbable" does not mean "impossible." There are certain conditions both sides could pursue to mitigate or even resolve the commitment problem: increased international involvement from China, the creation of a more equal political arena for both sides to resolve their differences, and the continuation of the Tatmadaw's policy of allowing rebel groups to retain their arms as a safeguard if the settlement fails. While these conditions are difficult to pursue and may conflict with the desires of the parties involved, they represent the cost of achieving peace and ending a forever war.

²⁸Carl Clausewitz, “On War Quotes by Carl von Clausewitz,” Goodreads, accessed November 21, 2024, <https://www.goodreads.com/work/quotes/2048326-on-war>.

²⁹Kelly Ng, “Myanmar Rebels Reject Embattled Junta’s Peace Offer,” BBC News, September 27, 2024, <https://www.bbc.com/news/articles/cj04955442ro>.

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